

PHILOSOPHY

OVERVIEW

Philosophy involves critical and creative thinking about fundamental questions: questions about the meaning of life, the nature of good and evil, the reliability of knowledge, the bases of human rights and responsibilities, the functions of government, the nature and value of art.

The philosophy courses in the social sciences and humanities curriculum provide students with an opportunity to think about philosophical questions in a rigorous way and to develop their understanding of the nature of philosophy as a general discipline as well as of various specialized branches of philosophy. In these courses, students explore a range of philosophical questions and learn how major philosophers and philosophical traditions have responded to these questions. Students also develop their philosophical reasoning skills: they analyse philosophers' responses to the big questions and formulate, communicate, and defend their own responses. In addition, these courses encourage students to consider the relevance of philosophy – including philosophical methods, questions, and insights – to their own personal lives as well as to broader social issues.

Philosophy: The Big Questions, Grade 11

University/College Preparation

HZB3M

This course encourages exploration of philosophy's big questions, such as: What is a meaningful life? What separates right from wrong? What constitutes knowledge? What makes something beautiful? What is a just society? Students will develop critical thinking and philosophical reasoning skills as they identify and analyse the responses of philosophers to the big questions and formulate their own responses to them. Students will explore the relevance of philosophical questions to society and to their everyday life. They will develop research and inquiry skills as they investigate various topics in philosophy.

Prerequisite: None

A. RESEARCH AND INQUIRY SKILLS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

Throughout this course, students will:

- A1. Exploring:** explore topics related to philosophical questions and/or issues, and formulate questions to guide their research;
- A2. Investigating:** create research plans, and locate and select information relevant to their chosen topics, using appropriate philosophical research and inquiry methods;
- A3. Processing Information:** assess, record, analyse, and synthesize information gathered through research and inquiry;
- A4. Communicating and Reflecting:** communicate the results of their research and inquiry clearly and effectively, and reflect on and evaluate their research, inquiry, and communication skills.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

A1. Exploring

Throughout this course, students will:

- A1.1** explore a variety of topics related to philosophical questions and/or issues (*e.g., Does a meaningful life require that there be a divine plan? Do people living in the present have a moral obligation to redress the wrongs done by their ancestors – for example, against Aboriginal peoples? Is science the best way to gain knowledge? Can a work of art be beautiful even if it portrays evil or ugly things? Can a society that is divided between the very rich and the very poor be just?*) to identify topics for research and inquiry
- A1.2** identify key concepts (*e.g., through discussion, brainstorming, use of visual organizers*) related to their selected topics
- A1.3** formulate effective questions to guide their research and inquiry
Teacher prompts: “If you were gathering supporting arguments and evidence for the statement ‘People who are obese should face constraints similar to those that are placed on smokers’, what questions would you ask? Whose perspectives would it be important to consider?”

A2. Investigating

Throughout this course, students will:

- A2.1** create appropriate research plans to investigate their selected topics (*e.g., outline purpose and method, identify sources of information*)
- A2.2** locate and select information relevant to their investigations from a variety of primary sources (*e.g., interviews; observations; original documents in print or other media such as film, photographs, music*) and secondary sources (*e.g., research reports, textbooks, websites, brochures, newspaper articles; critical analysis in journals or book reviews*)
Teacher prompt: “How can you determine whether a philosophical source is primary or secondary?”
- A2.3** based on preliminary research, formulate arguments and anticipate counter-arguments
Teacher prompts: “What are the strongest ideas that are emerging from your initial investigation?” “Can you identify an answer to a big question of philosophy that you can support or prove?”

A3. Processing Information

Throughout this course, students will:

A3.1 assess various aspects of information gathered from primary and secondary sources (*e.g., accuracy, relevance, reliability, inherent values and bias, perspective*)

Teacher prompt: “What steps can you take to ensure that your sources are reliable?”

A3.2 record and organize information and key ideas using a variety of formats (*e.g., notes, graphic organizers, summaries, audio/digital records*)

A3.3 analyse and interpret research information (*e.g., compare arguments that are made in a variety of sources*)

Teacher prompts: “Have you generated enough supporting arguments and evidence to defend your point of view effectively?” “Have you found compelling arguments or evidence that would weaken your position? Is your support for your view strong enough to counter these arguments?”

A3.4 demonstrate academic honesty by documenting the sources of all information generated through research

A3.5 synthesize findings and formulate conclusions (*e.g., determine whether their results support or contradict their hypothesis; weigh and connect information to determine the answer to their research question*)

A4. Communicating and Reflecting

Throughout this course, students will:

A4.1 use an appropriate format (*e.g., oral presentation, written report, formal debate, poster, multimedia presentation, web page*) to communicate the results of their research and inquiry effectively for a specific purpose and audience

A4.2 correctly use terms relating to their chosen topics

A4.3 clearly communicate the results of their inquiries (*e.g., write clearly, organize ideas logically, use language conventions properly*), and follow appropriate conventions for acknowledging sources (*e.g., generate notes and/or references using APA, MLA, Chicago, or Turabian style*)

Teacher prompts: “Have you included notes or a reference list in your work?” “Have you checked the appropriate style guide to ensure you are using the style correctly and consistently?”

A4.4 demonstrate an understanding of the general research process by reflecting on and evaluating their own research, inquiry, and communication skills

Teacher prompt: “How did you determine whether you had considered a wide enough range of arguments to justify your conclusion?”

B. PHILOSOPHICAL FOUNDATIONS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- B1. Identifying the Big Questions:** describe the main areas of philosophy and identify the big questions that arise in each area;
- B2. Philosophers and Philosophical Traditions:** demonstrate an understanding of how major philosophers and philosophical traditions approach some of the big questions of philosophy;
- B3. Defining Terms and Concepts:** demonstrate an understanding of terms and concepts central to discussions of the big questions of philosophy, and of how these terms and concepts are used in various philosophical traditions.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

B1. Identifying the Big Questions

By the end of this course, students will:

- B1.1** describe the main areas of philosophy (e.g., metaphysics, ethics, epistemology, philosophy of science, social and political philosophy, aesthetics)

Teacher prompt: “What is the difference between the fields of metaphysics and epistemology?”

- B1.2** identify the big questions associated with each of the main areas of philosophy (e.g., metaphysics: *Is there a supreme being? What is the nature of reality? What is the meaning of life?*; ethics: *What is a good person? Are there just wars? If so, what makes them just?*; epistemology: *What is truth? Is it possible to know the world as it truly is?*; philosophy of science: *What distinguishes science from other ways of knowing? What is the nature of scientific evidence? Is it ever possible, or desirable, for a scientist to be objective?*; social and political philosophy: *What are the limits of state authority? What is the best form of government? Why? What is social justice?*; aesthetics: *What is beauty? Is censorship ever justified?*)

B2. Philosophers and Philosophical Traditions

By the end of this course, students will:

- B2.1** describe some major philosophical traditions (e.g., Confucianism, Platonism, rationalism, empiricism, idealism, materialism), and explain how these traditions approach the big questions of philosophy

- B2.2** compare how different philosophers have answered the same big question (e.g., *Plato and Rawls on a question about justice; Aristotle and Danto on a question about the nature of art; Popper and Kuhn on a question about the nature of scientific knowledge; Hobbes and Sartre on a question about freedom; Kant and Mill on a question about moral obligation; Descartes and Hume on a question about the nature of knowledge; Aristotle and Wollstonecraft on a question about the role of women in society; Madhva and Ramanuja on a question about the nature of reality; Aristotle and Bentham on a question about the meaning of life; Conway and Descartes on a question about the nature of God; Shankara and Locke on a question about the self*)

Teacher prompt: “In what ways do the views of Hobbes and Rousseau differ on the question of why human societies form governments?”

B2.3 compare how different philosophical traditions approach the same big question (e.g., *Thomism and existentialism on a question about the meaning of life; rationalism and empiricism on a question about human knowledge; liberalism and libertarianism on a question about social justice; utilitarianism and Kantianism on a question about ethical theory; expressionism and formalism on a question about the nature of art*)

Teacher prompts: “How would Thomists and existentialists respond to the question ‘Does life have a purpose?’” “In what ways do rationalism and empiricism differ regarding the role of the senses in the acquisition of knowledge?” “What are the differences between Rawlsian and Nozickian liberalism regarding the question of whether social justice and individual freedom are compatible?” “What are the utilitarian and Kantian positions regarding the question of whether it is ever right to tell a lie?” “How do expressionists and formalists differ in their response to the question ‘Must an object provoke an emotional response to be a work of art?’”

B3. Defining Terms and Concepts

By the end of this course, students will:

B3.1 define terms central to philosophical discussions of the big questions (e.g., *personal identity, nihilism, scepticism, a priori, a posteriori, personhood, essence, feminism, consciousness, altruism, Socratic method, pluralism, determinism, perception, causality, freedom, soul, knowledge, truth, virtue, morality, objectivity, subjectivity, wisdom, social contract, justice, the ideal state, rights and responsibilities, representational art, formalist art*)

B3.2 explain the ways in which philosophical terms and concepts used by different philosophers have evolved over time, and describe how these terms and concepts are understood within different philosophical traditions

Teacher prompts: “How has the concept of beauty changed between ancient times and modern times?” “How might philosophers of aesthetics and metaphysics differ in their use of the term *soul*?” “What similarities and differences are there in the way John Stuart Mill and Simone de Beauvoir or Susan Moller Okin use the terms *equality* or *individual rights*?”

C. PHILOSOPHICAL SKILLS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- C1. Philosophical Reasoning:** demonstrate an understanding of terms, methods, and fallacies associated with philosophical reasoning;
- C2. Evaluating Philosophical Responses to Big Questions:** analyse, using their own philosophical reasoning skills as well as the arguments of other critics, the strengths and weaknesses of the responses of major philosophers or schools of philosophy to some of the big questions of philosophy;
- C3. Developing Philosophical Responses:** use philosophical reasoning and critical thinking skills to formulate responses to big questions of philosophy and to arguments encountered in everyday life.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

C1. Philosophical Reasoning

By the end of this course, students will:

- C1.1** describe the parts of an argument (*e.g., premise, evidence, conclusion*), and explain how a philosophical argument differs from other communications
Teacher prompts: “What is the difference between an argument in philosophy and an argument that is a quarrel between hostile antagonists?” “What is the difference between an argument, an explanation, and an anecdote?” “When listening to a speech or reading an article, what cues can you use to determine whether the speaker or writer is making an argument? What words are used to signal the premise and conclusion of, and evidence for, an argument?”

- C1.2** describe forms of reasoning (*e.g., deduction and induction*), and explain how they are applied in philosophical arguments

Teacher prompt: “Sunil has learned about cases of serious head trauma suffered by children who had bicycle accidents while not wearing helmets. Sunil does not want to suffer the same fate, so he wears a helmet whenever he rides his bike. Is Sunil using inductive or deductive reasoning? Give reasons for your answer.”

- C1.3** correctly use terminology related to logic and philosophical argumentation (*e.g., logical consistency, contradiction, deduction, induction, proposition, truth value, inference, validity; terms related to forms of arguments, types of syllogisms, patterns of reasoning*)

- C1.4** identify some common fallacies in reasoning (*e.g., fallacies related to relevance, such as an appeal to pity or emotion and an appeal to authority; fallacies related to ambiguity, such as equivocation and fallacies of composition and division; fallacies related to presumption, such as begging the question and using a straw man*), and identify examples of some of these fallacies in arguments encountered in everyday life (*e.g., in newspaper articles and editorials, advertising, formal debates, informal discussions*)

C2. Evaluating Philosophical Responses to Big Questions

By the end of this course, students will:

- C2.1** summarize arguments that critics have used to support, critique, or refute responses of major philosophers or philosophical traditions to some of the big questions of philosophy

Teacher prompts: “In what ways were the ideas of ancient Greek philosophers such as Plato and

Aristotle promoted and criticized in the work of Islamic philosophers such as al-Kindi, Ibn Sina (Avicenna), and al-Farabi?" "Which ideas of Enlightenment philosophers such as Descartes or Locke were critiqued by existentialists such as Sartre? Why?" "What criticisms did Nietzsche level against traditional moral philosophy?"

- C2.2** analyse, using their philosophical reasoning skills, the strengths and weaknesses of the main arguments made by major philosophers or philosophical traditions in response to some of the big questions of philosophy

Teacher prompts: "In what ways do Marx, Mill, and Plato differ in their views of democracy? Whose argument do you think is the strongest? Why?" "Is Rousseau's concept of the general will totalitarian or radically democratic?"

C3. Developing Philosophical Responses

By the end of this course, students will:

- C3.1** develop and defend, using philosophical reasoning and critical-thinking skills, their own response to one or more of the big questions of philosophy examined in this course

- C3.2** apply philosophical reasoning and critical-thinking skills to analyse arguments encountered in everyday life (e.g., in letters to the editor, newspaper editorials, news reports, formal debates, face-to-face or online discussions among peers) and to develop a response to them

Teacher prompt: "What fallacies of reasoning can you find in the remarks that readers have posted online in response to newspaper articles? What response might you develop to address the flawed reasoning and provide a different way of viewing the issue?"

D. THE RELEVANCE OF PHILOSOPHY

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- D1. The Relevance to Everyday Life and Society:** demonstrate an understanding of the relevance of philosophical questions, theories, and skills to their everyday life and to the community and broader society;
- D2. The Relevance to Education and Careers:** demonstrate an understanding of the relevance of philosophy to other subject areas and careers.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

D1. The Relevance to Everyday Life and Society

By the end of this course, students will:

- D1.1** explain the relevance of some of the big questions of philosophy to their own experiences in everyday life (*e.g., questions about power in relation to the issue of bullying, about social responsibility in decisions to engage in social action, about the existence of a supreme being and their approach to religion, about the self and others in their relationships with family and friends*)

Teacher prompts: “How do you determine whether an action is right or wrong?” “Have you ever felt justified in telling a lie? Why or why not?” “In what ways do your beliefs about the nature of men and women and their role in society affect your relationships and plans for the future?”

- D1.2** explain the relevance of some of the big questions of philosophy to their community and the broader society (*e.g., questions about the obligations of citizens and governments in Canadian and global politics; about equality and justice in policies regarding women, poor people, and ethnocultural minorities, including Aboriginal people; about ethics in debates about issues such as abortion, euthanasia, genetically modified organisms; about the relationship between nature and human beings in debates about environmental policy; about aesthetics and censorship in cultural industries*)

Teacher prompts: “What philosophical questions arise in relation to research into and the manufacturing of genetically modified organisms?”

“What is the relationship between questions of freedom, ethics, and social responsibility in anti-hate crime legislation?” “What ethical and metaphysical questions underlie the issue of human responsibility to protect the environment or endangered species?” “What philosophical ideas underlie politics in Canada? How do these differ from those that underlie politics in China?”

- D1.3** demonstrate an understanding of how they can apply philosophical theories and skills to enhance their understanding of popular culture (*e.g., movies; music; music videos; books such as fiction, graphic novels, pop psychology; television shows, including talk shows, reality shows*)

Teacher prompts: “What type of argument is being made in this advertisement? Is a fallacy implicit in the argument? How is it being used to influence the consumer?” “What does this music video imply about the role of women? What aspects of the video led you to that conclusion?” “Do reality TV shows reflect ‘reality’? Give reasons for your answer.”

D2. The Relevance to Education and Careers

By the end of this course, students will:

- D2.1** demonstrate an understanding of ways in which skills developed and used in philosophy, such as critical thinking, argumentation, and effective listening skills, can be used in other subjects (*e.g., when engaged in formal and informal debating, weighing evidence to reach a conclusion,*

writing essays, evaluating primary and secondary sources, formulating and defending an argument or thesis)

Teacher prompts: “Which philosophical reasoning skills would you use when evaluating primary and secondary sources for a research report?” “How might you use the skills developed in this course to evaluate an essay you have written for another subject?”

- D2.2** explain the philosophical presuppositions that are implicit in other subject areas (e.g., with reference to: the nature of knowledge in science; the possibility of objectivity in history; the basis for critical judgements in literature or art; ideas about free will and social responsibility in law, sociology, politics)

Teacher prompts: “What philosophical assumptions underlie the study of science and scientists’ views of what constitutes scientific knowledge?” “What is meant by the statement that ‘History is written by the victors’? What does this assertion reveal about presuppositions that

can underlie the reconstruction of historical events?” “How do critics determine whether a piece of music or writing is ‘art’?” “What notions of beauty predominate in fashion?”

- D2.3** explain the philosophical presuppositions that are implicit in a variety of careers (e.g., law, arbitration/mediation, journalism, public relations, politics, the civil service, lobbying, diplomacy, medicine or medical ethics, publishing, teaching and research, history, science, art, human resources, religious fields)

Teacher prompts: “What conception of justice is most evident in the Canadian Constitution, including the Charter of Rights and Freedoms? How might this conception affect how a lawyer approaches a human rights case?” “What are some of the presuppositions underlying the business ethics of specific corporations? Which philosophical schools do these presuppositions reflect?” “What assumptions about democracy are implicit in the goals and methods of the lobbying industry?”